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Christus Sacerdos in the Preaching of St. Augustine: Christ
and Christian Identity (review)

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stresses the fact that “Athanasius does not present himself as an exegete in his writings. . . . He showcases no exegetical learning, rarely offers multiple valid interpretations for a verse, and never says *oimai* to introduce an interpretation” as Origen frequently did (161).

Following a thorough examination of “the scripture-use habits represented in the historical-polemical writings” (208), with *typos* and *paradeigma* as key terms for the rather judgmental portrayal of Athanasius’ contemporaries, the next chapter describes “the Bible in the pastoral writings.” Ernest takes advantage of recent publications by E. A. Clark and D. Brakke. His study of *Festal Letters* would need some complementary research, but his notations on the *Life of Antony* are highly suggestive. By its concise clarity this whole chapter could serve as a methodological model for any graduate student wishing to engage in research on Athanasius’ works.

Finally, the author concludes that Athanasius’ “exegesis cannot be called scientific because he did not consistently apply any elaborate method” (369). “Athanasius was in some ways a simple man driven by one central idea, but in order to understand him more adequately, we need contributions from diverse methods and perspectives” (372). Ernest’s own contribution fulfils an obvious need and provides a new impulse to the critical retrieving of Athanasius’ legacy. By giving equally sharp attention to *all* parts of that legacy, that is, to the spiritual and pastoral writings as much as to the political apologies, the author presents a more adequate picture of the Alexandrian bishop than has been the case in the past century when the polemical bias of scholars themselves often clouded our understanding of the Athanasian corpus.

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Daniel J. Jones

Christus Sacerdos in the Preaching of St. Augustine:

Christ and Christian Identity

Patrologia: Beiträge zum Studium der Kirchenväter XIV

Frankfurt am Main: Peter Lang, 2004

Pp. 493. \$84 (paper).

On New Year’s Day, 404, North Africans were out in the streets celebrating the feast of Calends, joining in both traditional ceremonies and raucous revels. Augustine was in Carthage, it seems, and used the occasion to deliver a sprawling *magnum opus* of a sermon some three hours in length. He denounced in depth and detail the hazards of demon-wooing pagan rites and the dead end fallacies of pagan intellectualism. He then set out the Christian alternative: *Christus Mediator et Sacerdos*, Christ the mediator and priest, whose graced *sacramenta* redeem and transfigure his body, the church. This sprawl of a sermon is one of 26 new sermons, first discovered in 1990 by François Dolbeau, who found them buried in a fifteenth century Carthusian manuscript now preserved in the

Mainz Stadtbibliothek. Dolbeau's momentous discovery, published in a scatter of brilliant articles through the 1990s, have sparked scholarly conferences and a host of reassessments. This New Year's sermon (known as *s. Dolbeau 26*) has been acclaimed the "jewel" of the collection. As Peter Brown noted in the *New York Review of Books*, "modern scholars never dreamed that we would come so close again to Augustine's dialogue with living paganism."

Brown and others have probed *s. Dolbeau 26* for its tantalizing glimpses into Augustine's world, what it reveals of a not-yet-triumphant Christianity. Daniel Jones has focused, instead, on the sermon's theology. His *Christus Sacerdos*, based on a 2003 dissertation completed at the Augustinianum in Rome under Robert Dodaro, is a densely argued, text-focused study. His thesis is that Augustine in *s. Dolbeau 26* especially but in other sermons as well invokes the *Christus Sacerdos* title to do three things "in tandem": to explain "the identity and work of Christ, from which Christian identity originates"; to show "how this doctrine of Christ establishes for Christians an identity and ideal, telling them both who they are and what they are to become"; and to shape these two by defining them over against paganism's cluster of identities, practices, and worldviews (21–22).

Jones begins with Augustine's "critique of cultured paganism." He denies that Augustine's polemics were battles with a bygone reality; like Mandouze, he insists that Augustine "never had a taste for fighting phantoms" (54). Augustine's target was Neoplatonism, specifically the theurgic Neoplatonism of Iamblichus. The issue, as Jones crisply articulates it, was a clash over mediation, its contours, conceptions, and religious meanings. Christians and theurgic Neoplatonists agreed on the vast fissure separating God from humanity; they agreed, too, on the need for sacramental purification. But for the Neoplatonists the fissure was ontological and cosmological whereas for Augustine it was moral and spiritual. In Neoplatonist theurgy—what Augustine labeled *sacra sacrilegia*—lesser mediating spirits acted as go-betweens bridging cosmic gaps. Christian mediation differed ontologically: Christ the mediator "is not *between* Creator and man, but *is* both Creator and man." And Christ's mediation exacts a moral response: self-confrontation, repentance, and fraternal charity (90).

The heart of Jones' analysis focuses on Augustine's use of *sacerdos* including its "rhetorical load"—the cluster of cultural associations and connotations such terminology evoked in the audience. Jones rightly highlights how *sacerdos* stirred up images of pagan priestly fraternities with their complex ties to *polis* and government (not to mention animal sacrifice). He skillfully dissects three clusters of meaning Augustine gives to *sacerdos*: (1) Christ as a divinely just man; (2) his saving work (death, resurrection, ongoing heavenly intercession); and (3) his "shared identity" in the *Totus Christus* linking Christ's priesthood to the church's (163). Jones deftly teases out how, for Augustine, *mediator* and *sacerdos* broadly overlap yet possess distinct "centers of gravity," *mediator* in the Incarnation, *sacerdos* in the Paschal mystery (415). He also traces the interstices with other favorite titles, Christ the Head (*Caput ecclesiae*) and Christ the Great Sacrament (*magnum sacramentum*).

This is a dense, exhaustive work. Its 400+ pages include careful analysis but also much repetition, sometimes necessary, but at other times the remnants of a

dissertation's wooden mechanics. Jones focuses unswervingly on the *content* of Augustine's thinking. What gets overlooked is Augustine's heart, his spontaneity, his uncanny ability to tap into his audience's deep-seated feelings, the often dizzy excitement of these noisy, extemporaneous dialogues with the crowd.

Reviews such as this often close with the comment that "such and such a book would be profitably read by students, seminarians, faculty, etc." Let me recommend this work especially for one group: systematic theologians. Why? Because it teases out how this newly discovered Augustine grappled with burning systematic questions: who is Christ? what is priesthood? what is sacrament? how do Christians stand vis-à-vis the wider culture? This new Augustine may have something to say to those whose professional task it is to ponder such questions.

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John Moorhead
Gregory the Great
 The Early Church Fathers
 New York: Routledge, 2005
 Pp. 177. \$29.95.

With the introduction of this volume Moorhead's work joins a promising series on the early church fathers, which seeks to provide an introduction to the lives of important Greek and Latin authors and to give a sampling of their writings in English translation. Although thus far the series seems to have favored the eastern fathers, this volume moves the collection toward greater balance.

The first section of the work includes discussions of Gregory's life and deeds, his works, the Bible in Gregory's thought and writings, his life as a thinker, and his understanding of the human mind. In tracing the history of Gregory's life Moorhead notes his patrician beginnings and his time in civil service before moving to his ecclesial service as *apokrisarius* in Constantinople and his papacy. In a few pages the author does a good job of demonstrating the character of Gregory's leadership as well as the extreme obstacles he faced. The introduction to Gregory's works is very helpful in contextualizing the material, and the author's discussion of the Bible both demonstrates how central Scripture was to Gregory's thought and provides a good entry into the bishop's exegetical method. Moorhead demonstrates Gregory's penchant for allegory and typology very well but is not so clear on the distinction between the two in Gregory's mind.

The author's discussion of Gregory as a thinker follows. Though he attempts to rise above Harnack's crude assessment of Gregory, he argues that "in the history of Christian theology his place is secondary" (26) even though some modern scholarship has done a good job of pointing out the difficulties involved in such an assessment. Nevertheless, this part of the book correctly outlines Gregory's overriding concern with hypocrisy and heresy, his rich understanding of the spiritual life, and his dependence upon Augustine, Ambrose, and the Stoic tradition.